

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN BERMUDA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the coast and open spaces of Bermuda, and the fight over Southlands shows how a community can save a pristine place from a resort even when the government has already cleared the way to build. When the government issued a special development order in 2007 to let developers raise a luxury resort hotel on the Southlands estate — some thirty-eight acres of unspoilt coastal woodland, beach, and quarry gardens in Warwick Parish that a premier himself called "an unspoilt jewel" — Bermudians did not simply accept it. A coalition of environmental and community groups formed and pressed: they lobbied, they made the case for Bermuda's dwindling green spaces, and they held roadside demonstrations with placards that were, for Bermuda, a first. The public lobbied against paving over the pristine land, and the government brokered a land swap: the developers took eighty acres of brownfield land at Morgan's Point for their resort, and Southlands was preserved — becoming, in time, a national park.

The Southlands story teaches two things about stopping destructive projects here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly and up front. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the community, the evidence, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Bermudian. **A community here can save a treasured place from development through an environmental coalition, public lobbying, peaceful demonstration, and the pursuit of a land swap and lasting park protection — even after a development order has been granted.** That combination — the coalition, the public case, the demonstration, and the land-swap-and-protection outcome — is the distinctive lever here, and this guide is built around it.

But the same story carries honest qualifications this guide places first and takes seriously. The Southlands win was real, but it was **a land swap, not an outright cancellation**: the resort itself was not stopped, only moved — built elsewhere, on brownfield land at Morgan's Point. The community saved this particular pristine site; it did not stop the development entirely, and honesty requires saying so. The win also took **years** — from the 2007 furore through the 2010 swap agreement, the government's acquisition of Southlands in 2012, and its formal designation as a national park in 2017. And even a saved place needs defending: Southlands as a park has since faced **neglect, disrepair, and renewed debates** over what "development" within it should mean. This guide does not pretend the win was simple or final. What it shows is how a community turned a pristine site slated for a resort into a national park — and how those levers can be used again.

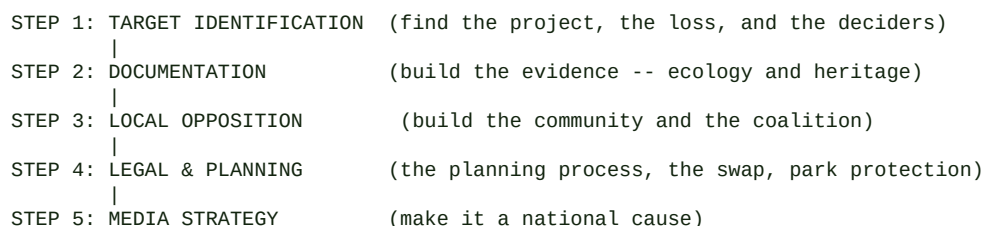
Most communities do not know HOW to make their concern effective. They hear that a green space or a coastline will be developed and assume "the order is granted and nothing can be done," and never build the coalition, never make the public case, never pursue a swap or park protection. They generate private regret without organised opposition. The gap between places saved and places paved is rarely apathy — Southlands proved a community will act, and even take to the roadside. It is method: knowing how to build the coalition, make the case, demonstrate peacefully, and pursue a swap and lasting protection.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Bermuda system as it is, and grounded in a fight the community, in the end, won. It is written for the person who has heard that a treasured green space, a

stretch of coast, or an irreplaceable piece of Bermuda's heritage is slated for development, and who wants to know whether anything can be done once the plans are advancing. The answer is yes, with the honest qualifier that a Bermudian win may be a swap that redirects development rather than stops it, and a protection that must then be defended — and that the way to it runs through coalition, public pressure, and the pursuit of lasting park status. A note on who this guide is for, and on the spirit in which it should be used. It is for the person willing to work through coalitions, planning submissions, public persuasion, and, where warranted, peaceful demonstration — the methods that saved Southlands. That is not a lesser form of action but, in a small and civil society, the most effective one, because it builds the credibility and the breadth that a Bermuda government heeds. The guide is honest that this took years, that the win was a swap rather than a stop, and that the saved place has needed continued defending. But it is equally honest that the woodland stands and the place is the island's, and that is a real, repeatable achievement. Read it not as a promise of easy victory but as a map of how a small, determined community used coalition, evidence, and a credible alternative to save a place its own government had cleared for development.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to save a coastal estate, a woodland, an open space, or another treasured place from development:



These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The ecological and heritage evidence feeds the coalition, the media, and the public at once; the coalition grows; a demonstration or a planning submission is both pressure and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins what can be won here — a place saved, a development redirected, a park protected. The Southlands campaign did exactly this.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every jurisdiction's system has its own pressure points. Bermuda's — a small, close-knit island where open space is scarce and treasured, with a strong national-parks tradition — give communities a distinctive set:

- **The environmental coalition.** Established groups — **BEST, Greenrock, the National Trust, the Audubon Society** — carry weight, as they did at Southlands.
- **The scarcity of open space.** A **small island's dwindling green space** makes the case for saving it powerful, as Southlands' beauty did.
- **Public lobbying and peaceful demonstration.** A **mobilised public, even at the roadside**, moves a close-knit society, as Bermuda's first such protest did.
- **The land swap.** A **swap redirecting development to brownfield land** is a distinctive, pragmatic outcome, as Morgan's Point was.
- **National-park protection.** The **National Parks Act and lasting park status** can secure a saved place, as Southlands eventually gained.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers guarantee an outright, permanent stop. Southlands was **a swap, not a cancellation**; it took **years**; and even a park **must be defended** from neglect and renewed development. This guide takes those limits seriously — it states them first and throughout — and shows how to use the real, distinctive tools this system offers — the coalition, the public case, the demonstration, the swap, and park protection — as they were used to save a pristine coastal jewel that the government had already cleared for a resort.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the project — or the leverage — is weakest. And map what would be lost and where the coalition, the planning process, and the possibility of a swap or park protection apply, because in Bermuda a treasured place is often best saved by building the coalition, making the public case, demonstrating peacefully, and pursuing a swap and lasting protection, as Southlands was.

The Levels of Decision

A Bermuda development runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government. The **Government of Bermuda** issued the development order for Southlands and later brokered the swap; it is the decider a coalition and a public must move, as the Southlands campaign moved it.

The planning process. The **planning authorities and development orders** — including special development orders like the one granted for Southlands — set what may be built, and are a place to object and challenge.

The national-parks system. The **National Parks Act and the parks system** can secure a saved place with lasting protection, as Southlands gained park status.

The environmental bodies and heritage. The **conservation and heritage considerations** — endemic species, open space, historic value — weigh in decisions, as Southlands' ecology and beauty did.

The public and the coalition. The **environmental groups, the National Trust, and the mobilised public** are the levers that give a case its force, as they gave Southlands'.

The Journey of a Project

A typical development moves from a proposal and a planning order, through approvals and financing, toward construction — with the **community's evidence, the coalition, the planning process, the possibility of a swap, and the public** able to intervene, even after an order is granted, as Southlands showed. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in**, and the coalition and the public case pressed toward a swap or protection is the distinctive door here. The distinctive levers are the **coalition, the public case and demonstration, the planning process, the land swap, and park protection**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what treasured place would be lost, whether a swap or alternative site exists, and how the planning process and park protection apply**, because those are often where a place can be saved.

Follow the Project, the Place, and the Deciders

Behind a project stand a proponent — often developers with government backing — and the approvals it needs. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly here — **what ecological and heritage value the**

place holds, whether an alternative or brownfield site could take the development, how the planning process applies, and whether lasting park protection is possible. Two questions unlock most Bermuda fights of this kind: **What would be lost, and is there a better place for the development?** and **Where — the coalition, the public, the planning process, a swap, park protection — can that loss be turned into a save?** The coalition and the public case are, together, the heart of most such campaigns. It is worth naming why this pairing is so potent in Bermuda specifically. The coalition supplies credibility and institutional weight — the standing of established groups a government cannot dismiss as cranks — while the public case supplies the political pressure that makes the coalition's arguments impossible to ignore. In many places a community with a strong case still struggles to be heard; in Bermuda, a strong case carried by a credible coalition and a mobilised public reaches a government directly, on an island small enough that the whole society is, in effect, in the room. That is why a campaign here should invest early and heavily in both: the coalition that makes the case credible, and the public mobilisation that makes it politically weighty. Neither alone saved Southlands; together they were decisive.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that shape a decision, because they are levers too. The **planning authorities**; the **national-parks system** and the **National Parks Act**; the **conservation and heritage bodies**; the **National Trust**, **BEST**, **Greenrock**, and the **Audubon Society**; the **local press**; and the **close-knit public** for whom open space is precious. In Bermuda, the **coalition, the public case and demonstration, the planning process, the land swap, and park protection** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a treasured place whose loss is documented, championed by an organised coalition, lobbied against by a mobilised public, and offered a better alternative through a swap rarely goes to development untouched — as Southlands did not, being saved and, in time, made a national park. The lesson for any Bermuda community is to make its project fight look like that from the start: the value documented, a credible alternative in hand, the coalition assembled, and the public engaged, all at once, so that the government faces not a single objection it can manage but a convergence of credibility, public feeling, and a workable deal that points toward saving the place.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly — and here that means knowing the win may be a swap that redirects development rather than an outright stop, and a protection that must then be defended. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how open-space and heritage fights tend to go on a small island, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community can **document the ecological and heritage value**, whether it can **build a credible coalition and mobilise the public**, whether a **swap or alternative site** exists, and whether **lasting park protection** can be secured. Where the place is treasured and the coalition strong, the levers here are real, as Southlands shows; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that a development order may already be granted, that the win may be a swap rather than a stop, and that a saved place still needs defending.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	10–20%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step
Ecology & heritage case	40–65%	weeks–months	low	The value at stake, established

protection. Southlands shows the ceiling: a credible coalition, a public case, and Bermuda's first roadside demonstrations turned a resort-cleared jewel into a national park — through a swap. But it also shows the honest limit: the resort was redirected, not stopped, and the win took years and the park still needs defending. Most Bermuda fights of this kind will sit between a Southlands save and a place developed, and the honest lesson is that the coalition and the public case are strong levers here — able to save, redirect, and protect a place — but that against a determined government the realistic win may be a swap, a delay, or concessions, with an outright, permanent stop the harder outcome.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The coalition and public lobbying** — Bermuda's foundation for these fights; the organised, credible movement that moves a close-knit society, as at Southlands.
2. **The ecology and heritage case** — the value of a scarce, treasured place, documented.
3. **The land swap** — the distinctive lever; redirecting development to a better site.
4. **Park protection** — securing a saved place lastingly under the National Parks Act.
5. **Peaceful demonstration and the public** — the mobilised society whose attention shifts decisions.

What These Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur, at Southlands and in Bermuda's open-space fights. **Scarcity makes the case** — on a small island, a treasured green space is worth defending, and people know it. **The coalition carries weight** — established groups moving together are listened to. **The public will mobilise** — even to the roadside, a first for Bermuda. **A swap can save a place** — redirecting development to brownfield land is a real, pragmatic win. **But orders get granted, and saved places need defending** — Southlands was a swap, and its park has needed care. The through-line: **document the value; build the coalition; mobilise the public; pursue a swap and lasting protection** — because a community that does can save even a place the government has cleared for development, as Bermudians saved Southlands, while being honest that the win was a swap and the protection an ongoing task.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact project and loss that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which here is often the coalition, the public case, and the possibility of a swap. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the resort cleared for this thirty-eight-acre coastal jewel of endemic woodland and beach, when brownfield land elsewhere could take it instead" is a campaign — the kind that saved Southlands. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. **What treasured place would be lost?** This is the first question here. What **ecological and heritage value** — open space, endemic species, coast, beauty — would the development destroy, as Southlands' woodland and shore held.
2. **Is there a better site for the development?** Is there **brownfield or alternative land** that could take the project instead, as Morgan's Point took the Southlands resort.
3. **What coalition can be built?** Which **environmental groups, the National Trust, and the public** will stand together, as BEST, Greenrock, and others did.

4. How do the planning process and park protection apply? Which planning objections, development-order challenges, or park-protection paths are open, as the special development order and the National Parks Act were central.

5. Who decides, who profits, and who is with us? Which government and developers are behind it, who profits, and which groups and public will stand with the community.

A Worked Example

Suppose a resort is cleared for a pristine coastal green space, with an order already granted.

Working the five questions: **what treasured place would be lost? Is there a better site? What coalition can be built? How do the planning process and park protection apply?** And the deciders are the government and developers, with the coalition, the public case, the planning process, a swap, and park protection as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "the order is granted and nothing can be done" to a plan: document the value; build the coalition; make the public case and demonstrate; pursue a swap to a better site; and seek lasting park protection. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it is exactly how Southlands was saved.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where a close-knit society is moved by a treasured place and a swap needs a credible alternative, the ecological, heritage, and site evidence is decisive. A planning authority, the public, a journalist, and a government weighing a swap all move on evidence, not indignation — and in a Bermuda open-space fight, a clear record of what would be lost and where it could better go is precisely what a campaign turns into a save, so build it well. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Order, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its developers, the land it would take, and the planning order behind it** — including any special development order, as Southlands had; and establish **which planning, conservation, and park provisions** apply. Establish the deciders and the project precisely, because they are what the evidence must move, and note that an order already granted can still be overtaken by a swap and protection, as Southlands' was. Pay particular attention to identifying every approval and step the project still requires, because each one is both a deadline and an opening — a point at which the community can object, propose the swap, or seek protection. A project with steps still ahead of it is far more open to redirection than one already built, so map that path early and note where along it the community can intervene.

Layer 2: The Value and the Alternative

Document the reality the proponents would rather keep vague, and here the **ecological and heritage value, and the alternative site, are central**. Establish, with environmental groups and experts, the place's **open space, endemic species, coastal and heritage value** — what makes it, in a premier's own words at Southlands, an "unspoilt jewel." And establish the **alternative** — the brownfield or lesser site that could take the development instead, as Morgan's Point could take the resort. Photographs, species records, heritage

detail, and a credible alternative make both the loss and the better path undeniable. The value plus the alternative is the case that saved Southlands. Give equal care to documenting why the alternative is not merely available but preferable — that brownfield or already-disturbed land often suits a large development better, sparing the cost and delay of clearing pristine ground, and sparing the developer the reputational burden of destroying a beloved place. Framed this way, the swap is not a concession the developer grudgingly accepts but, sometimes, a better deal for everyone, and a campaign that can make that case turns an adversary into a potential partner in the swap.

Layer 3: The Loss, the Swap, the Protection, and the Leverage

Finally, document the case. Does the **ecological and heritage value** show a place worth saving? Is there a **viable swap or alternative site**? Do the **planning process and park protection** give a path? And where is the **leverage** — the coalition, the public, the government's own conservation credentials? Each is a separate element, and together they make a case a government can act on — as it acted at Southlands, brokering the swap and, in time, the park. This is the layer that most often decides these fights, because here a treasured place, a credible alternative, a planning and protection path, and an organised public are joined — exactly the case that saved Southlands. Build it well, and the value, the alternative, and the coalition become the community's strength. One practical note on building this layer: treat the alternative site with the same rigour as the threatened one, because a vague or implausible alternative undoes the whole strategy. It is not enough to gesture at "somewhere else"; the campaign must be able to show a specific site that is genuinely available, genuinely suitable for the development in question, and genuinely lower in ecological cost. At Southlands the alternative was brownfield land at Morgan's Point — already disturbed, arguably better suited to a large resort, and owned in a way that made a swap feasible. Do the work to find and stand up such a site, consulting those who know the island's land, because a credible, documented alternative is what transforms the campaign from a plea into a proposal the government can actually accept.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Evidence in hand beats evidence you assume exists. Here is where the material tends to live in a Bermuda open-space fight, and how to get it — with the **ecological and heritage value**, the **alternative site**, and the **planning and park handles** at the center. Treat this as a checklist to work through, not a menu to admire.

The Project and Order Record

Start with the project itself. **Planning applications, development orders, and any special development order** are matters of record and show what is intended and where it stands, as the Southlands order did. **Government statements and agreements** establish the deciders and the timeline. Establish exactly **what the project is, who is behind it, and where in the approval path it stands**, because a place not yet developed can still be saved, and an order granted can still be overtaken by a swap and protection.

The Ecological and Heritage Evidence

This is the heart of the file. Gather, with the **National Trust, BEST, Greenrock, the Audubon Society, and naturalists**, the evidence of the place's **open space, endemic and native species, coastal and marine value, and heritage** — the woodland, the shore, the historic features, as Southlands' banyans, quarry gardens, and beach held. Photographs, species records, and expert and heritage assessments make the value vivid and credible. On a small island where open space is scarce and treasured, this evidence is the single most powerful thing this file can contain.

The Alternative-Site Evidence

Document the better path, because in Bermuda a swap is often the win, and a swap needs a credible alternative. Establish the **brownfield or lesser sites** that could take the development instead — their suitability, their availability, their lesser ecological cost, as Morgan's Point's brownfield land took the Southlands resort. A community that can say not merely "not here" but "there instead" gives the government a way to say yes to preservation, so document the alternative as carefully as the loss.

The Planning and Park Handles

Identify the levers the process provides. The **planning process and development-order rules** allow objection and, sometimes, challenge. The **National Parks Act and the parks system** offer a path to lasting protection, as Southlands gained. The **conservation and heritage provisions** weigh in decisions. Map which apply — the objection windows, the protection paths — because in Bermuda the route from a saved place to a secured one runs through park protection, and the route to saving it may run through the planning process and a swap.

The People and the Allies

Finally, map the human terrain. Who is affected or connected — the parish, the neighbours, the users of the open space? Who are the **groups** already organising, as BEST and Greenrock were? Who are the **naturalists, the National Trust, the sympathetic public figures, the press**? A Bermuda open-space fight is won by a community joined to the environmental coalition and a mobilised public — so map your coalition, especially its established environmental members, as deliberately as your evidence. A word on the particular allies a Bermuda fight offers, because they are distinctive and well-established. Bermuda has a mature environmental civil society for so small a place: BEST, which cut its teeth as protectors of the island's open spaces at Southlands itself; Greenrock, which grew out of earlier open-space fights; the Audubon Society, with its ornithological standing; and the National Trust, with its conservation authority and its properties. These are not groups a community must invent; they exist, they have fought and won before, and they bring credibility, networks, and institutional memory. Reach to them early and deliberately, because a Bermuda open-space fight is won by a community joined to this established coalition — not by a community starting from nothing.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Evidence does not move deciders by itself. A community — organised into a coalition, informed, and willing to lobby and, if need be, demonstrate — is what turns the value and the alternative into a save a government backing the development cannot ignore. Southlands proved a close-knit society will act, even to the roadside; the task is to organise that will into a coalition and a campaign.

Why the Community Is Decisive

A government can dismiss an individual objection; an organised coalition and a mobilised public are harder to wave away, especially on a small island where reputations and relationships run deep. The community supplies what a campaign runs on: the coalition's credibility, the local knowledge, the volunteers, the public voice, and the legitimacy that makes a case a national cause. When a community stands together — as Bermudians did at Southlands, in coalition and at the roadside — a government's backing meets a real political cost, and a path to a swap and a save opens. **A united community is not the backdrop to the campaign; it is the campaign's engine.** On an island as small and interconnected as Bermuda, this is truer still than elsewhere. Everyone is, in some sense, a neighbour; the environmental groups, the National

Trust, the parish community, and the wider public are not distant constituencies but overlapping circles of the same close society. That intimacy is the community's advantage. A coalition here does not have to manufacture connection across a vast population; it has to activate connections that already exist — the naturalist who knows the minister, the Trust member who writes for the paper, the parish that has picnicked at the threatened place for generations. When those existing bonds are turned toward a shared cause, a Bermuda campaign gains a density of support that a larger place cannot easily match. Build the coalition not as strangers assembling, but as a community remembering what it already shares.

Finding the Affected Community

Begin with those the project touches most — the **parish, the neighbours, the users of the open space** — as Warwick's community valued Southlands. Widen to everyone on a small island who treasures its dwindling green space, which is nearly everyone. Name the shared stake — **our open space, our coast, our heritage, our island** — because that is what turns scattered residents into a movement, and a movement into a coalition that can save a place. The framing matters especially where land is scarce. On a small island, every acre developed is an acre gone for good, and Bermudians know it in their bones; the open space that remains is not one amenity among many but a dwindling inheritance. A fight cast narrowly — as one estate's fate, or one group's preference — is easy to set aside. A fight cast as a stand for the island's shrinking open space, its endemic species found nowhere else on earth, and the heritage passed down through generations is one that nearly the whole island can join. Do not let the project be framed as a routine planning matter; frame it as a question of what little wild Bermuda has left, and whether this generation will be the one to pave it. That larger frame is both truer and stronger, and it is the frame under which Southlands was saved.

Coalition-Building

A community allied is stronger than a community alone, and in Bermuda the coalition is the campaign's spine. Reach deliberately to the **established environmental groups** — BEST, Greenrock, the Audubon Society — which led at Southlands; the **National Trust**, with its conservation standing; **naturalists and experts**; **sympathetic public figures**; and the **wider public** who will lobby and demonstrate. Breadth signals that this is not a fringe objection but a shared defence of the island's open space and heritage, and it is the coalition, more than any single voice, that a Bermuda government heeds.

Sustaining Momentum

Bermuda campaigns can run for years — Southlands spanned from 2007 to a 2017 park designation. Sustain the community with **transparency, small wins, and shared purpose**. Mark each step — a coalition formed, a demonstration held, a planning objection filed, a swap agreed, a park declared. Because the fight may run long and end in a swap and a protection rather than a quick stop, keep the coalition warm and the public engaged across the years. And carry the work past the save: a protected place, as Southlands shows, needs continued care and vigilance against neglect and renewed development. The community that lasts is the one that stays informed, sees its wins, and keeps its eyes on the place it is defending — and on defending it still, once saved. This last point deserves emphasis, because it is where many campaigns relax too soon. Winning the save — the swap, the reprieve, even the park designation — feels like the end, and the coalition that fought for years understandably wants to rest. But a protected place is not a finished one. Southlands, saved and designated, went on to face neglect, invasive species, disrepair, and fresh proposals for development within the park. A community that disbands at the moment of victory leaves its hard-won place exposed to slow decline and quiet redevelopment. The discipline, therefore, is to convert the campaign into stewardship: to keep enough of the coalition alive to watch over the place, to hold the

government to its protection, and to resist the renewed pressures that a valuable saved site inevitably attracts. The save is the beginning of the guardianship, not its end.

STEP 4: LEGAL & PLANNING CHALLENGES — THE PLANNING PROCESS, THE LAND SWAP, AND PARK PROTECTION

This is where a Bermuda open-space fight is often decided — not always in the courtroom, but through the **planning process, the pursuit of a land swap, and the securing of park protection**, backed where needed by legal challenge. Used well, these are among the most powerful levers a Bermuda community has, even after a development order is granted, as the Southlands fight showed.

Setting Expectations Honestly

First, the honest truth, and here it is central. These levers are **real but not automatic, and the win they yield may be a swap rather than a stop**. A development order may be **already granted**, as Southlands' was; a **swap depends on a viable alternative** and a willing government; and **park protection can take years** and must then be defended. A planning objection or legal challenge can **delay, constrain, or overturn** an approval, but the durable Bermuda win at Southlands came not from a courtroom victory but from a **negotiated swap and, in time, park status**. Enter this front clear-eyed: the planning process, the swap, and park protection are the distinctive Bermuda levers, strongest when the **place is treasured, the alternative is credible, and the public is mobilised** — but the win may redirect development rather than end it.

The Planning Process

The first front is planning. The **planning authorities, the development-order process, and any special development order** set what may be built, and are where a community objects, submits evidence, and, where grounds exist, challenges. Learn the **objection windows, the criteria, and the appeal or review routes**, and press the ecological, heritage, and open-space case through them. Even where an order is granted, sustained planning pressure and public opposition keep a project contestable and open the door to a swap, as they did at Southlands. This is the front to engage first.

The Land Swap

The second and distinctive front is the swap. Bermuda's durable open-space wins often come not from stopping a development outright but from **redirecting it to a better site** — as the Southlands resort went to brownfield land at Morgan's Point. Identify and document a **credible alternative site**, and press the government to broker a swap that saves the treasured place while letting the development proceed elsewhere. A swap lets a government backing the investment still say yes to preservation, which is why it is so powerful here. It is worth adding that the swap must be pursued actively, not merely awaited: the community that identifies the alternative, checks its feasibility, and presents it as a near-ready option does far more to make a swap happen than one that simply objects and hopes the government will invent a solution. The Southlands swap did not materialise on its own; it emerged because a credible alternative existed and pressure made brokering it the government's least-cost path. Do that work yourselves, and you shorten the road to a save. Come not only with "not here" but with "there instead," and you offer a way to a win. It is worth dwelling on why the swap is so distinctively powerful in Bermuda, because understanding it changes how a campaign is built. A government committed to a development is committed, usually, to what the development brings — the jobs, the investment, the tourism — far more than to the specific patch of ground. A bare objection asks the government to give up those benefits; a swap asks it only to relocate

them. That is a far easier yes. The genius of the Southlands outcome was that it let the developers build their resort and let the island keep its jewel, by moving the project from pristine woodland to brownfield land that arguably suited a large resort better anyway. A community that grasps this will invest early in finding and documenting the alternative site, treating it not as an afterthought but as half the campaign — because in Bermuda the credible alternative is often the difference between a demand the government resists and a deal it can accept.

Park Protection

The third front is lasting protection. A saved place is secure only when protected, and the **National Parks Act and national-park designation** are how Bermuda secures its open spaces — as Southlands was declared a national park in 2017. Press for that designation once a place is saved, because a swap or a reprieve without protection can be undone, and even a designated park, as Southlands shows, must be defended from neglect and renewed development. This front is slow and continuing, and this guide will not pretend otherwise — but it is what turns a save into a lasting one, and the long work of securing and defending park status is the real endgame of a Bermuda open-space fight. Understand, too, that park designation is a floor, not a ceiling, of protection. Southlands became a national park, yet even that status did not end the pressures on it: proposals for renovation, public-private partnerships, and development within the park have recurred, and neglect has threatened it as surely as any bulldozer once did. The community's task after designation is therefore twofold: to hold the government to the protection the law promises, resisting attempts to erode it under the banner of "improvement," and to help steward the place actively — through clean-ups, monitoring, and advocacy — so that a park saved on paper remains a park in fact. A designation defended is worth far more than a designation won and forgotten.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself; you must aim it at each decider in the language that moves them. The same file of ecology, heritage, and alternatives becomes different arguments for a planning authority, the government, a journalist, and the public. Translate deliberately.

For the Planning Authorities

The planning bodies respond to **the rules, the evidence, and workable alternatives**. Frame the place's value in planning terms: the open space and heritage lost, the criteria the development fails or strains, and — powerfully — the alternative site that could take it instead. Give them the ecological and heritage evidence and a path to a better outcome. Make it easy to protect and defensible to redirect: *here is the value, here is the loss, here is a better place for it*. Give the planning authorities, too, the cover of a strong public record, because officials find it far easier to refuse or redirect a development when a documented, credible community case is on the file behind them. A well-argued objection is not only an argument; it is political cover for a decision-maker inclined to protect the place but wary of standing alone. Officials rarely act against a project entirely on their own initiative; they act when a documented, credible, public case gives them both the justification and the political room to do so, and providing that case and that room is among the most valuable things a campaign can do.

For the Government

The government responds to **public feeling, its own conservation credentials, and a workable deal**. Frame the choice as the Southlands outcome was framed: a chance to preserve an unspoilt jewel and still let development proceed, through a swap, in a way a government can be proud to claim. Give them the

public support, the treasured place, and the credible alternative, so preservation becomes the choice they can make and celebrate. Offer a deal, not just a demand. A government handed only a demand must choose between the community and the investment; a government handed a deal can have both, and can claim credit for the wisdom of the outcome. That is the posture the Southlands campaign ultimately achieved, and it is the posture most likely to succeed: not to defeat the government, but to hand it a way to be the one who saved the jewel.

For the Coalition and the National Trust

The coalition and the Trust respond to **a credible, shared cause**. Give them sound evidence, a clear ask, and a united front, so their standing and their networks amplify the case. Their credibility is a lever only if the campaign is rigorous and united, so make the ecology, the heritage, and the alternative strong enough for the established groups to stake their names on, as they did at Southlands. Remember that established groups guard their credibility carefully, because it is their chief asset across many fights; they will lend it fully only to a campaign whose evidence and conduct they can trust. Earn that trust with rigour and restraint, and the coalition's standing becomes your own.

For the Media and the Public

The press and the public respond to **beauty, loss, and clarity**. Translate the file into a story anyone can grasp: an unspoilt coastal jewel, its endemic woodland and beach, about to become a resort — and a community that lobbied, marched, and won it back as a park. The beauty, the scarcity of open space, the David-and-Goliath shape — these make a Bermuda story, as they made Southlands'. It helps to remember what actually moved the public in that case: not abstract argument but the tangible reality of the place — its endemic trees, its quiet shore, the sense of a rare open space on a crowded island. Lead your storytelling with that tangible reality, letting people picture and feel what would be lost, because on a small island the emotional truth of a beloved place is often more persuasive than any statistic, and it is what turns readers into a coalition. Keep it accurate; a close-knit society values credibility and remembers overreach.

The Golden Rule

Never fabricate, never exaggerate. Your credibility is your greatest asset, and on a small island it is quickly tested and long remembered. State the acreage, the species, and the alternative precisely, distinguish estimate from established fact, and be honest — including that the win may be a swap rather than a stop, and that a saved place must be defended. This honesty extends to how you describe the government and the developers, and on a small island it is both right and strategic. Describe a development decision you oppose as a policy choice you disagree with, backed by economic aims you can question, rather than as a scheme or a betrayal. Overstating turns a winnable argument into an easy target, and in a place where everyone knows everyone, a reputation for fairness is worth more than a moment's rhetorical advantage. The Southlands campaign kept the door open to a swap precisely by remaining a credible negotiating partner rather than an implacable foe; a community that vilifies the government forecloses the very deal that might save the place. Be firm about the value and the loss, generous in acknowledging the development's legitimate aims, and constructive in offering the alternative, because that combination is what makes a swap possible. A community that is precise and honest, especially about the value and the alternative, is far harder to dismiss than one that overreaches.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media and public attention convert your evidence into the pressure the deciders feel, and here the story — an unspoilt jewel about to be lost, and a community that saved it — is one a small island responds to.

Why Media Matters

A government backing a development, and a close-knit public, both respond to a well-told story. Media does three things here: it **informs and mobilises the public**, it **raises the political cost** of paving a treasured place, and it **frames the choice** as beauty and heritage against a resort. At Southlands, coverage of the unspoilt jewel and the campaign to save it helped move the decision toward a swap and a park. A fight kept public, on a small island, is a fight the whole community follows.

Crafting Your Narrative

Lead with the place and the loss. The strongest frame is concrete and warm: *an unspoilt coastal jewel — its endemic woodland, its beach, its heritage — about to become a resort, when a better site exists, and a community determined to save it*. Put the place and the people first, let the ecology and the alternative follow, and invoke the island's scarce, shared open space. Keep it accurate; overstating the harm or dismissing the development's case hands the other side its rebuttal. The Bermuda story is powerful because the place is genuinely treasured and the alternative genuinely better.

Choosing Your Channels

Match the channel to the audience. **Local press and radio** for the whole island; **the environmental groups' and Trust's channels** for the engaged base; **social media** for speed and mobilisation; **naturalists and respected figures** for credibility; and, where a place is of wider significance, **regional and heritage media**. Because Bermuda's fight turns on a close-knit public's feeling for its open space, the channels that reach and move that public are the ones that matter most.

A Few Cautions

Stay accurate and fair, especially on the ecology and the alternative, and toward the government and the developers — the goal is a credible public case and a workable swap, not exaggeration. Protect the community; keep private individuals out of the glare unless they choose it. And sustain it: a Bermuda fight can run for years and end in a swap and a protection, so pace the story — a coalition formed, a demonstration held, a swap agreed, a park declared — to keep the island engaged across a long campaign, and past the save into the defence of the park.

EMAILS & LETTERS: TEMPLATES THAT WORK

Templates save time and prevent mistakes, but adapt every one — insert the real project, the real ecological and heritage detail, and the real alternative, keep it factual, and never overstate. Here precision on the value and the alternative matters more than force.

8A: Requesting Information from the Planning Authorities

Subject: Request for information — [project], planning and alternatives

Dear [official],

I am writing on behalf of [community/group] regarding [project] at [location]. To participate meaningfully in the decisions affecting this open space, we request: the **planning application and any development order**; the **environmental and heritage assessments**; the **land and habitat affected**; and any

consideration of alternative sites. Please advise how to obtain these and how to object.

We would be grateful for a response by [date].

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8B: Letter to the Government Proposing a Swap

Subject: Preserving [place] — a better site exists

Dear [Minister/official],

We write regarding [project], which would develop [place], a treasured [woodland/coast/open space] of [ecological/heritage value]. We ask the Government to consider preserving [place] and redirecting the development to [alternative/brownfield site], which could accommodate it at far less cost to our island's open space — as Southlands was saved by the Morgan's Point swap. This would let development proceed while preserving an irreplaceable place, an outcome the Government could be proud to broker.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8C: Letter to the National Trust

Subject: Standing together to save [place]

Dear [Trust],

Our community opposes the development of [place], a [woodland/coast] of real ecological and heritage value. We ask the National Trust to lend its standing and expertise to the campaign to save it, as the Trust and the environmental groups did at Southlands. Our documentation, including [evidence], establishes the value at stake. May we work together to preserve this piece of Bermuda's heritage?

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8D: Letter to an Environmental Group

Subject: Join the campaign to save [place]

Dear [BEST/Greenrock/Audubon],

We are [group], working to save [place] from [development]. Your expertise and voice would strengthen the coalition, and the island's dwindling open space is a stake we all share. We are documenting the value and seeking a swap and lasting protection. May we discuss how we might work together, as the coalition did at Southlands?

In solidarity,

[Name, community, contact]

8E: Media Pitch

Subject: An unspoilt jewel, about to become a resort

Dear [journalist],

At [location], [place] — [an unspoilt coastal jewel of endemic woodland and beach] — is cleared for [a resort], though a better site exists at [alternative]. Our community is campaigning to save it. There is a clear story here — the beauty, the scarce open space, the community's stand — echoing Southlands. We can provide the ecology, the heritage, the alternative, and voices.

May we send a briefing?

Sincerely,

[Name, community, contact]

8F: Coalition Outreach

Subject: Save [place] with us

Dear [organisation],

We are [group], opposing [development] at [place], a treasured [open space] our island can ill afford to lose. Your [expertise/voice/standing] would strengthen our coalition, and the open space is a stake all Bermudians share. We are pursuing a swap and park protection. May we discuss working together?

In solidarity,

[Name, community, contact]

8G: Letter to a Naturalist or Expert

Subject: Request for expertise — ecology of [place]

Dear [name],

Our community is working to save [place] from [development]. Your assessment of its **endemic species, habitats, and ecological value** would give our case the credibility it needs, as naturalists' knowledge did at Southlands. Might you assess the site, or point us to the records? We are grateful for any help.

Respectfully,

[Name, community, contact]

8H: Rallying the Community

Subject: Our open space — let us save it together

Dear neighbours,

[Place] — [a treasured jewel of our island's dwindling open space] — is cleared for [development]. But we can save it, as Bermudians saved Southlands, by standing together, lobbying, and, if need be, taking peacefully to the roadside. Please join us: come to [meeting], sign [petition], and add your voice. Together we can preserve what is ours, and pass it on.

With determination,

[Name, community group]

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Sometimes a project is moving fast — an order granted, works near — and you cannot run the full campaign. Triage to the levers that move fastest, and here that means the coalition, the public case, and the alternative.

The First 48 Hours

Establish the essentials: **what the project is, what treasured place it would take, whether a better site exists, and where it stands**. Identify the immediate pressure point — a **planning objection window, an approval, a works date** — because that is what you must affect first. Reach the **established environmental groups and the National Trust** at once, because a credible coalition is the fastest way to weight, as it was at Southlands.

The Fastest-Moving Levers

Some levers work faster than others. **A stark ecology-and-loss fact** — the acreage, the endemic species, the beauty — can shift a debate in days. **A credible alternative site** — "there instead" — gives the government a fast way to yes. **A coalition statement** from the established groups carries weight immediately. **A peaceful demonstration** draws a close-knit society's attention at once, as Bermuda's first did. **A media story** of an unspoilt jewel travels fast. These outpace the slower work of a swap and park protection, though those may follow. The reason this order works is that a stark, credible fact about a beloved place does two things at once: it gives the press and the public something concrete to rally around immediately, and it raises the stakes of proceeding for a government that must now act in full public view. On a small island, a single vivid image — the endemic woodland, the open shore about to be lost — can move public feeling within days, and public feeling is the currency a Bermuda government cannot ignore. That swift mobilisation is what buys the time for the slower machinery of the planning challenge and the swap to engage, and it costs almost nothing but speed and credibility.

Emergency Coalition-Building

You cannot build a broad coalition overnight, but you can activate a fast one. Reach immediately to **BEST, Greenrock, the Audubon Society, the National Trust**, and any **naturalist** who can speak to the value. A handful of credible voices raising the loss and the alternative at the right moment — before an approval or works — can buy the time the fuller campaign needs. Speed favours the prepared: know your value, your alternative, and your coalition before the deadline. And if you are caught genuinely flat-footed, with an order granted and works near, concentrate everything on the two fastest levers: a stark, credible statement of the treasured place's value and imminent loss, aimed at the press and the public; and a swift approach to the established environmental coalition, whose standing can command attention at once. Those two, deployed quickly, can generate the public pressure and the credible voice that buy time — for a planning challenge, for a swap proposal, for the fuller campaign. Do not try to build everything in a week; raise the alarm credibly and activate the coalition, win a pause, and then build toward the swap and the save. A delay secured is the ground on which the real campaign is fought. And a delay is often more achievable than it seems, because governments and developers alike prefer to avoid the reputational cost of visibly steamrolling a mobilised public over a beloved place; even a committed proponent will frequently accept a pause rather than force a confrontation, and that pause is the opening a prepared community needs.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Sometimes you do everything right and still face a wall — not because your case is weak, but because the government backs the development. This is Bermuda's honest truth for these fights, and Southlands

embodied it: the order was granted, the developers engaged, before the community could mount its defence. Name it plainly, because pretending the field is level wastes effort and hope.

Recognising a Tilted Field

The signs are specific. The **order is granted** and the government is committed. **Economic pressure** — the island's reliance on tourism and investment — favours the development. **Precedent and momentum** run with the project. When the government is set on a development, the ordinary levers — an objection, a lone voice — may be blunted, and you must widen the fight, above all toward the coalition, the public, and the swap.

Strategies for a Tilted Field

When the field tilts, change the game. Shift weight to the levers the government responds to even when committed: the **coalition** and the **mobilised public**, which raise the political cost; the **credible alternative and the swap**, which let the government preserve without simply losing the investment; **peaceful demonstration**, which a close-knit society notices; and **park protection**, which secures a save. Make the treasured place and the better alternative so public that paving it carries a price, and offer the government the swap that saved Southlands. Build the record even when you cannot yet win, because a documented, public, well-argued case keeps the project contestable and opens the door to a swap. A tilted field lengthens the odds; it does not end the fight, and Southlands was won on exactly such ground. There is a second reason a tilted field is survivable in Bermuda specifically: the island's smallness and its cycles of government mean that public feeling, once genuinely mobilised, is hard for any administration to ignore for long, and that a project's momentum can stall across the years such fights take. Southlands' developers and the government of the day were committed, yet a sustained coalition and a mobilised public, over years, shifted the outcome to a swap and eventually a park. A community that keeps its case alive and its coalition warm is positioned to seize the moments when the political weather changes — a shift in public mood, a change of administration, an economic wobble that makes a swap more attractive to the developers themselves. Endurance, on a small island where everyone eventually hears everything, is not merely patience; it is the strategy of keeping a treasured place's case before the whole community until the balance tips toward saving it.

The Honest Possibility of Losing — and of a Partial Win

You may lose, and this guide will not pretend otherwise; you may also win only partly, as a swap that redirects development rather than a stop that ends it. Both truths belong here, and the Southlands win was itself a swap. If you lose, the work is still not wasted: the **value was documented, the coalition built, the public mobilised, the record made, and the next fight — for another place, or for the protection of a saved one — starts stronger**. And if you win a swap, be honest that development moved rather than ended — though redirecting it from a pristine jewel to brownfield land is a real and worthy outcome. Fight to win a save; accept a swap that redirects; and defend, afterward, the place you protected. That is the honest shape of open-space victory in Bermuda.

WHEN IT'S NOT CORRUPTION — AND WHY THE OBSTACLE IS USUALLY POLICY

In some countries this section would concern corruption; in Bermuda, honestly, that is rarely the obstacle, and it is fair to say so. Bermuda is a stable, rule-of-law jurisdiction, and the wall an open-space campaign meets is almost always **genuine development and economic policy** — a government that wants the

investment, jobs, and tourism a project promises — not graft. Distinguishing the two matters, because the response differs.

Telling Policy from Wrongdoing

A government backing a development for the economy, even wrongly, is making a policy choice, not a corrupt one, even where you disagree with it. The marks of a policy obstacle are openness and rationale: a stated economic purpose, a transparent process, planning channels open. Be rigorous and fair: **do not mistake a development decision you oppose for wrongdoing**, and do not level accusations the evidence does not support — on a small island especially, an unfounded accusation is both wrong and self-defeating. The honest, and usual, situation is a government genuinely weighing the economy against open space, and the campaign's task is to shift that balance with a treasured place, a public, and a credible alternative.

Responding to a Policy Wall

A policy wall calls not for exposure but for persuasion, evidence, and a better deal. Push the levers the government respects: the **coalition**, the **mobilised public**, the **credible alternative and swap**, and the **government's own conservation credentials and love of the island**. Make preserving the place the choice a government can be proud to make and can still square with the economy through a swap, as at Southlands. Where a genuine grievance about process arises, raise it lawfully and through proper channels; but expect, and prepare for, a fight of persuasion and a negotiated swap, not of exposure.

A Note on Safety and Care

Bermuda is a stable, orderly jurisdiction, and the risks here are not those of repression — this is a fight waged in coalitions, planning submissions, the press, and peaceful demonstration, not one of danger. Still, exercise judgment. Keep the campaign **lawful, documented, and collective**. Keep demonstrations **peaceful and orderly**, as Southlands' roadside protests were. Protect private individuals from unwanted exposure, and be fair to opponents in a small society where relationships endure. And sustain the community for a long fight and, afterward, for the defence of the saved place. Care for the people, and for the island's shared civility, is part of winning. There is a particular reason civility matters in Bermuda: the same small society that a campaign mobilises is the one it must go on living in, and the relationships strained in a bitter fight endure long after the fight is over. A campaign that wins its place but poisons its relationships with the government, the developers, and its neighbours has won at a cost that a small island feels for years. The strongest campaigns, Southlands among them, are firm without being rancorous — insistent on the value of the place, but respectful of opponents who remain fellow Bermudians. Guard that civility deliberately, not only because it is right, but because it keeps open the negotiated swap that is often the path to victory, and because the coalition that wins with grace is the one still trusted to fight the next fight.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps in this guide are written in sequence but run in parallel, each feeding the others. Here is how they fit into a single campaign against a destructive development in Bermuda.

The Parallel Campaign

From the start, the five run together. **Documentation** builds the ecology, heritage, and alternative-site file. **Target identification** aims it at the deciders. **Local opposition** organises the coalition and the public. **Legal and planning** work presses the planning process, the swap, and park protection. **Media** makes it a national cause. The value and the alternative feed all five at once — a documented jewel and a credible alternative are evidence, a media story, a reason to join, and the basis of a swap together. Run in parallel, they compound; run one at a time, they stall. The compounding is the whole point. Consider how a single strong fact — the endemic species found at the threatened place, or the suitability of the alternative site — travels across all five fronts at once: it is, in the same week, evidence for a planning objection, a headline for the press, a reason for a naturalist to join the coalition, and an argument in the swap negotiation. A community running the fronts separately would have to win each of those several times over; a community running them together wins them once and lets the fact ripple. This is why the guide insists on parallel operation rather than a tidy sequence. You do not finish documentation and then begin the coalition; you build the coalition around the documentation as it grows, and press the planning process and the media and the swap with each new fact. The campaign is not a relay but a chorus, and the value of the place and the promise of the alternative are the notes it holds.

A Rough Timeline

Early (weeks 1–8): establish the project, the value, the alternative, and the deciders; find or build the coalition; begin the documentation and the planning objection. **Middle (months 2–12):** build the coalition and the public case; demonstrate peacefully; press the planning process and propose the swap; make it a media story. **Later (months and years):** pursue the swap and, once a place is saved, secure and defend park protection — the Southlands fight ran from 2007 through a 2017 park designation and beyond. A Bermuda fight can be a marathon, and the defence of a saved place has no end; pace the campaign for both. A practical way to pace it is to organise the campaign around its decision points rather than the calendar: the planning objection windows, the moments when a swap can be proposed, the park-designation steps, and the later reviews that threaten a saved place. Plan the visible pushes — the demonstrations, the media, the coalition statements — for these moments, when they land hardest, and use the quieter stretches to build the case, grow the coalition, and prepare the next step. A campaign that strains continuously will exhaust itself before the moments that matter; one that builds quietly and acts at the decision points conserves its strength for a fight that may run for years and a guardianship that never quite ends.

The Core Discipline

Through it all, hold the discipline that wins these fights: **document the value and the alternative; build the coalition; mobilise the public; pursue the swap and lasting park protection — and keep every claim precise and honest.** The community that presses all five, grounded in a treasured place and a credible alternative, joined to the environmental coalition, and prepared for a long fight and a longer defence, is the one that saves even a place the government has cleared for development — as Bermudians saved Southlands, turning an unspoilt jewel cleared for a resort into a national park.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive development in Bermuda is genuinely possible, and the Southlands fight shows both how — and, honestly, how the win may take the shape of a swap and a protection rather than an outright stop. The task is not to find a single silver bullet but to press every lever together: the coalition, the public case and demonstration, the planning process, the land swap, and park protection.

Some honest truths hold across every campaign here. **The coalition and the public case are the foundation, and the land swap is the distinctive weapon. The planning process and park protection secure a save, and a close-knit society can be mobilised. But orders get granted, the win may redirect development rather than end it, and a saved place must be defended, as Southlands has needed.** Hold both truths at once: real power, real qualifications.

Above all, keep the discipline that gives these fights their strength. Build the ecology, heritage, and alternative file. Build the coalition and mobilise the public. Press the planning process, pursue the swap, and secure park protection. And be honest — including about the odds, about the swap being a redirection, and about the ongoing work of defending a saved place — because a precise, honest community defending a treasured jewel, and offering a better place for the development, is far harder to defeat than a project hoping no one offers an alternative.

Southlands was cleared for a resort by a development order, an unspoilt jewel that a premier himself openly admired even as he negotiated its development away. And still Bermudians saved it — building a coalition, making the case for their dwindling open space, taking peacefully to the roadside for the first time in the island's history, and pressing a land swap that sent the resort to brownfield land and turned the jewel into a national park. It was a swap, not a stop, and the park has since needed defending; this guide has said so plainly. But the woodland stands, the beach is open, and the place is the island's. That is the plainest measure of what a determined community achieved, and of what another can achieve again. The tools that saved it are real, the coalition and the swap the strongest among them, and they are available to any community willing to organise. Your island's open spaces and heritage are worth defending, and worth the years and the vigilance such a defence demands; the odds are better than "the order is granted and nothing can be done," and the fight — waged the way Southlands was — is one worth waging. Bermudians won it. So can you. A determined and credible community, speaking for a beloved place and offering a better path, is a formidable thing on a small island indeed. And they did it not with power of the kind the government and the developers held, but with organisation, evidence, a credible alternative, and the willingness — a first for the island in its tradition of quiet civility — to stand at the roadside with placards for a place they loved. They documented the jewel, built a coalition of the island's environmental groups and its National Trust, made the case for their dwindling open space, and offered a better site for the resort. None of that required resources the developers could deny them; all of it required credibility, persistence, and unity. Bring those to bear, work patiently through the coalition and the planning process and the swap, pursue lasting park protection, and prepare to defend the place even after it is saved, and you give your island's open spaces their best chance. The odds are better than surrender, and a treasured place, once genuinely defended by its community, is a hard thing for any developer to take. Hold onto the specifics of how Southlands was won, because they are the whole lesson: the community did not merely protest, it proposed; it did not merely object, it offered a better path; and it did not merely win a save, it pursued the protection and, however imperfectly, the guardianship that followed. Those are choices any community can make. Make them, work through the coalition and the swap and the park, and defend what you save, and you give your island's open spaces their best chance in a system that, for all its pressures, still lets a determined and credible community turn a jewel cleared for development into a park held in common.